

**Mr. Apratim
Purakayastha,**
Executive Vice President,
CTO Skillsoft

A learning experience

We sit down with the folks at Skillsoft to understand their Indian operations.

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Q What is Skillsoft's positioning in the eLearning space?

Purakayastha: Skillsoft is the world's leading corporate eLearning company which delivers engaging content on our renowned technology platform, Percipio, for modern enterprises. Skillsoft provides eLearning content to over 3000 enterprises worldwide and over the past 20 years have established ourselves as the number one brand in cloud-based corporate learning. The content includes courses, videos, books and other resources on Business and Management Skills, Leadership Development, Digital Transformation, Technology & Developer, Productivity and Collaboration Tools and Compliance.

Q What kind of technologies are being developed in Skillsoft?

Purakayastha: We have a significant investment for product development in terms of tens of millions of dollars, which is quite a large investment. You will find this in line with any other technology company, such as Google. So, we're focusing on building several technologies to support our business. First, we've taken a new architectural approach internally, which is based on microservices, which allow us to build very rich distributed applications, quickly.

We build microservices using modern technologies like node.js to represent different parts of a system. That is architecture. From a technical point of view, we are applying a large amount of machine learning and a large amount of data science in the way we operate. For example, we look at a learner's behavioral patterns, their whole behavior through a session, where they are going, and make very personalised recommendations for them.

We are aware of the learner's skillset, and we match their skillset with skills related to our content, and we also recommend based on their interests. So, a combination of microservices technologies and AI technologies are being used in the platform. We are also working with a partner currently that uses blockchain technology. Blockchain is becoming very important because we are seeing more and more people needing secure but portable credentials. Blockchain provides you with a secure and portable certificate, or a badge, if you may. We're also working with a partner who provided these blockchain-based badges to us. Those blockchain-based certifications or badges will be part of our platform.

Q Can you tell us about any patents that you have?

Purakayastha: At Skillsoft, we do not patent that much. We're working at the cutting edge of architecture and AI. I do

see us filing for patents in the area of learning recommendations based on AI. The patent culture has not been very strong in Skillsoft, because we are much more of service provider/content culture. The technology patent culture is just coming up. I have a strong background from IBM, where I personally filed for a lot of patents. At Skillsoft, we are now trying to create more of a patent and innovation culture. We don't have technology patents right now.

Q How do the India operations fit in?

Purakayastha: We have more than 600 people in Hyderabad and other metro cities. Just to make a point on the sense of scale, the 600 people represent more than 25 percent, almost close to 30 percent of our whole company. From a human capital point of view, we're very invested in India in terms of hiring engineering talent, engineering content development and all of that. There is a reason of course. We believe that in addition to providing intellectual property to our global markets, India itself is a big and emerging market for corporate eLearning. We focus a lot on technology and developer kind of content here, because of the IT heritage. Because the market is diversifying here, we are also finding a lot of demand in our business skills, digital transformation, and that type of content. India is not only an area of investment for us, it is also a big opportunity. 